

Moorish Spain

The conquest of a large part of the Iberian peninsula by Islamic Moors from 711 CE brought a new concept of art and architecture into an area more familiar with Christian traditions. For the next eight centuries, mosques, castles and residences were built in a blend of Islamic and Christian styles, though this mixed tradition lasted longer in some places than others. For instance, the Christian recapture of Barcelona in 801 left little time for Moorish influence to establish itself, while the longer-lasting settlement of Aragón and eastern Castile left an extensive legacy including the 12th-century Aljafería Palace in Zaragoza. In Andalusia, where the Muslim presence extended over 800 years, Moorish buildings are even more prevalent. Under the rule of the Syrian prince Abd ar-Rahman (756–88 CE), Córdoba was transformed into a prosperous city. At its centre rose the Great Mosque (built from 785 and extended by subsequent rulers). Its giant, double-storey horseshoe arches of red and white stone (opposite) stand on 856 columns of jasper, onyx, marble and granite, forming 19 naves.

